UNRWA Situation Report #237 on the Humanitarian Crisis in the Occupied Palestinian Territory (the Gaza Strip and the West Bank, including East Jerusalem)

All information updated for 7 October – 20 October 2026[1]

Days 1095-1108 since the start of the war in the Gaza Strip.
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Displaced families living in makeshift shelters face increased risks of flooding as winter approaches, with limited options for safer shelter © October 2026 UNRWA Photo.

Highlights

The Gaza Strip

- On 12 October, UNRWA opened a new health facility in Jabalia and began receiving patients. As UNRWA's northernmost health facility in the Gaza Strip, the clinic expands access to health services for underserved communities. Together with the Saftawi Health Centre, the two facilities provide new anchor points for delivering health services to thousands of Palestine Refugees in the area.
- UNRWA recorded several significant armed incidents affecting its facilities and schools-turned-shelters. At least six displaced people, including a child, were injured and one person was killed while sheltering inside UNRWA facilities, mostly as a result of stray bullets. Operations at several facilities across Rafah, Khan Younis and the Middle Area were also temporarily suspended, either due to insecurity or following evacuation orders issued by Israeli forces.
- UNRWA's winterisation response is underway, with winter emergency teams activated across all areas to clean manholes, gullies, and drainage networks, identify high-risk locations, inspect

[1] Some information reported may relate to periods outside the reporting timeframe.

available equipment, and put preventive measures in place, including sandbags in flood-prone areas. Winterisation preparedness, however, remains seriously constrained by limited operational capacity: many pumps to address flooding are not functioning due to lack of engine oil and spare parts, and heavy machinery cannot enter Gaza.

The occupied West Bank, including East Jerusalem

- Marking three years since the attacks of 7 October 2023, movement and access re-strictions were tightened across the occupied West Bank.
- The olive harvest season officially commenced on 15 October, accompanied by settler violence and access restrictions impacting Palestinian farmers in several areas of the occupied West Bank. During the reporting period, one Palestinian was reportedly killed in an incident related to settler violence.

1. Key points

The Gaza Strip

Fatalities and Injuries

- Between 7 October 2023 and 9 October 2026, according to the Ministry of Health, as reported by the Health Cluster, 74,370 Palestinians were killed in the Gaza Strip and another 175,371 were injured. This includes 1,481 fatalities and 5,410 injuries between the announcement of a ceasefire agreement on 10 October 2025 and 9 October 2026.
- UNRWA has recorded 394 colleagues killed in the Gaza Strip since the start of the war (311 UNRWA personnel and 83 persons who were supporting UNRWA[2]), as of 20 October.

Health crisis

- Hypothermia remains a serious risk, particularly for newborns and infants, with deaths reported in previous winters since the war began. UNRWA health and nutrition teams are strengthening counselling for women and caregivers on breastfeeding, skin-to-skin care and other simple measures to keep children warm. Infant warming units are being distributed across UNRWA health facilities to address emergency cases. However, supply restrictions have prevented the entry of additional warmers for community distribution, while use of existing units depends on unreliable electricity supplies.
- In September, six UNRWA health centres also experienced temporary disruptions due to overloaded generators having to be switched off until new lubricant oil can be found. This highlights the growing operational impact of the shortage of fuel, lubricant oil, and spare parts on the delivery of healthcare.

Wash, sanitation and hygiene (WASH) needs

- According to the WASH Cluster's Light Touch Monitoring Survey, completed in September, 84 per cent of the population are experiencing frequent, unpredictable disruptions in access to safe, clean, and reliable water for daily drinking, cooking, and hygiene. Water insecurity thus remains a significant concern, despite signs of improvement (91 per cent of the population reported water insecurity in the previous round).
- Access to basic hygiene supplies also remained severely constrained, with 89 per cent of households reporting insufficient access to essential hygiene items.

[2] Including 20 people supporting UNRWA killed while on duty.

Displacement, site management

- UNRWA continues to monitor the movement of displaced persons and displacement sites. A total of 113 UNRWA collective emergency shelters host 65,000 internally displaced persons.

Shelter needs

- According to the Shelter Cluster's classification, based on surveys conducted between 14 and 28 June, an estimated 1.98 million people, representing 94 per cent of the population of the Gaza Strip, require shelter and non-food item assistance (NFI). The assessment also suggests that 58 per cent of the population is facing critical or catastrophic shelter needs, meaning severe deficiencies in shelter conditions or lack of access to essential services and NFIs that expose them to serious health, safety, and dignity risks.

Operational implications and humanitarian response

- Around 10,500 Palestinian UNRWA personnel continue to provide services and assistance to people in the Gaza Strip. In the occupied West Bank, UNRWA also plays a central role with over 4,000 of the Agency's Palestinian personnel providing education, health, and other services to Palestine Refugees.
- All UNRWA international staff are prevented from entering the Occupied Palestinian Territory - the Gaza Strip and the West Bank, including East Jerusalem. This follows the implementation of laws passed by the Israeli parliament on 28 October 2024[3] that purport to prohibit UNRWA's operations in areas that Israel considers its sovereign territory, including occupied East Jerusalem, and seek to bar any contact by Israeli officials with UNRWA. **The Israeli authorities have not granted the Agency's international staff visas or permits to enter the Occupied Palestinian Territory, including Gaza, since the end of January 2025.**
- Since March 2025, the Israeli authorities have been blocking UNRWA from directly bringing humanitarian personnel and aid into the Gaza Strip. Despite the huge needs on the ground, UNRWA was therefore unable to distribute the aid it had pre-positioned outside Gaza, which included enough food parcels, flour, and shelter supplies for hundreds of thousands of people.

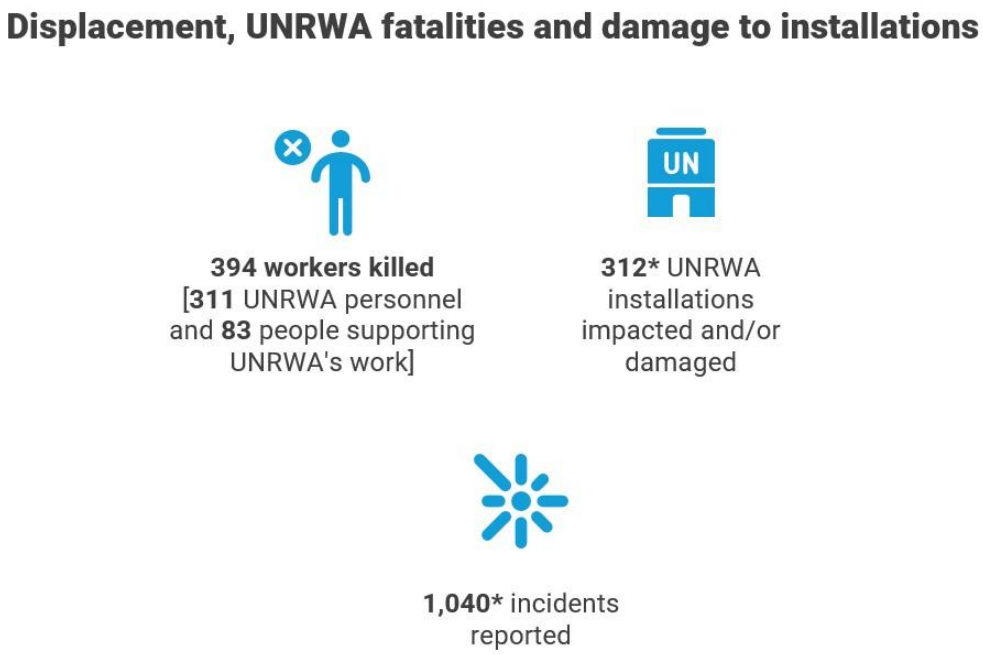
The occupied West Bank, including East Jerusalem

- According to OCHA, between 7 October 2023 and 9 October 2026, 1,143 Palestinians – at least 250 of them children – were killed in the occupied West Bank, including East Jerusalem. Ninety-six of them have been killed since the beginning of 2026.
- Marking three years since the attacks of 7 October 2023, movement and access restrictions were tightened across the occupied West Bank.
- Settler violence and harassment continued to account for a significant percentage of recorded protection incidents, with 395 incidents and at least 115 related injuries reported from 7-20 October alone. In addition to widespread reports of obstruction and attacks targeting the olive harvest, sustained pressure on Palestinian communities is contributing to an increasingly coercive environment and heightened protection concerns.
- A Palestinian from Burqa was reportedly killed in the context of settler violence on 7 October. Other Palestinians sustained injuries during the incident. The incident underscores the high levels of settler violence currently affecting Palestinian communities, particularly during the olive harvest season.
- On 10 October, a Palestinian from Beit Ula was shot and killed by Israeli forces using live ammunition in Hebron City.

[3] The legislation came into effect on 29 January 2025.

- Israeli forces have continued to keep all entrances to Madama village closed since 11 October.
- The olive harvest season officially commenced on 15 October, accompanied by settler violence and access restrictions impacting Palestinian farmers in several areas of the West Bank. On 16 October, in Abu Falah, a foreign journalist was among the injured. On 17 October, in At-Tayba, a European diplomatic delegation came under attack during a visit to observe the olive harvest.

2. Gaza humanitarian overview and response



Humanitarian access and armed conflict-related incidents[4]

- From 6 to 19 October, several significant armed incidents impacted UNRWA facilities, personnel, and persons supporting UNRWA's activities:
  - On 6 October, at approximately 16:00, an UNRWA school in Maghazi was reportedly struck by bullets during shelling by Israeli forces in the surrounding area. Three displaced people were reportedly injured. No damage to the school or casualties among UNRWA staff were reported.
  - On 7 October, at approximately 07:30, an UNRWA school in Jabalia was reportedly struck by bullets from quadcopters being operated by Israeli forces in the area. One child was reportedly injured inside the school. No damage to the school or casualties among UNRWA staff were reported.

[4] UNRWA is verifying details of incidents that reportedly impacted the Agency's premises, assets, and/or personnel. Additional information will be provided once it becomes available.

- On 8 October, at approximately 08:35, UNRWA temporarily suspended activities at a Health Centre and a Temporary Learning Space due to an Israeli military operation in the areas of Shakoush, Rafah, and South Eqlimi, Khan Younis. No damage to the facilities or casualties among UNRWA staff were reported.
- On 8 October, at approximately 13:00, an UNRWA educational tent in the yard of an UNRWA school in Khan Younis was reportedly struck by bullets fired by Israeli forces in the area. No damage or casualties among UNRWA staff were reported.
- On 11 October, at approximately 14:30, a stray bullet reportedly struck an UNRWA school in Khan Younis. The source of the bullet is unknown. A displaced person was reportedly injured at the school's main gate.
- On 14 October, at approximately 17:00, an UNRWA school in Jabalia was reportedly struck by a bullet fired by Israeli forces in eastern Jabalia. A displaced person was reportedly killed inside the school. No damage to the school or casualties among UNRWA staff were reported.
- On 14 October, at approximately 11:00, UNRWA temporarily suspended activities at an UNRWA school in Deir al-Balah due to an Israeli military operation in eastern Deir al-Balah.
- On 18 October, at approximately 16:00, a stray bullet reportedly struck an UNRWA school. The source of the bullet is unknown. A displaced person was reportedly injured. No damage to the school or casualties among UNRWA staff were reported.

Summary of displacement orders

- On 15 October 2026, at 17:19, UNRWA's field security risk management team was notified by UNDSS of an evacuation order issued by Israeli forces for two UNRWA installations in Maghazi. At approximately 18:15, Israeli forces reportedly carried out an airstrike at a location near the two installations. No damage to the facilities or casualties among UNRWA staff were reported.

- Since the beginning of the war and up to 19 October, **1,040*** incidents impacting UNRWA premises and the people inside them have been reported. **312*** (or nearly all) UNRWA installations have been impacted by armed conflict-related incidents, some of them multiple times. UNRWA continues to verify and update the number of casualties caused by these incidents.

**Since the war began in October 2023, the latest casualty figures are continuously under review as UNRWA gains access to locations that were previously inaccessible and as further verifications occur. The summary figures will be published/updated as information becomes available, noting that these numbers are subject to change once verifications are concluded.*

UNRWA response

Health and nutrition

- UNRWA has provided nearly 20 million health visits, including approximately 14 million medical consultations, since the start of the war in the Gaza Strip in October 2023.
- From 1 to 15 October, UNRWA screened 5,484 children aged between six and 59 months at its health centres and medical points, identifying 93 malnourished children.
- By 18 October, seven health centres and five additional UNRWA-rented facilities, used as temporary health centres, were operational in the Gaza Strip. In addition, by that date, UNRWA was providing primary health services through 65 mobile medical teams working in 24 medical points

inside and outside collective emergency shelters in the Middle Area, Khan Younis, Al Mawasi, and Gaza City[5].

- From 5 to 18 October, an average of 1,250 UNRWA health personnel per day worked in the Agency's health facilities across the Gaza Strip, providing 146,727 medical consultations in total.
- Between 5 and 18 October, UNRWA health teams provided 15,543 consultations for post-natal and pregnant women at high risk, 7,258 dental and oral health consultations in fixed and mobile clinics, and 4,974 physiotherapy rehabilitation services sessions in health centres and medical points. A total of 18,537 laboratory tests were conducted in UNRWA health centres and medical points.
- From 5 to 18 October, 6,241 vaccination sessions were provided at health centres and medical points.
- UNRWA's telemedicine initiative began in March 2024 and has gradually expanded to include other services such as teledentistry, telephysiotherapy, and telepsychosocial counselling. Currently, following the establishment of the Centralised Telemedicine Centre, the team provides teleconsultations for curative outpatient care, non-communicable diseases, as well as maternal and cardiological consultations.

Mental Health and Psychosocial Support (MHPSS)

- UNRWA remains one of the largest providers of emergency learning and psychosocial support (PSS) services across the Gaza Strip.
- Between 7 October 2023 and 19 October 2026, UNRWA's social work teams provided services to 285,900 displaced persons, including psychological first aid, PSS, family and individual activities, and case management. During the same reporting period, services were provided to 6,230 survivors of gender-based violence (GBV) and 12,052 children, including 4,373 unaccompanied children. The teams supported 40,209 persons with disabilities through PSS. Awareness sessions on GBV, child protection, disability inclusion, as well as managing social and psychological stressors, were conducted for 170,481 displaced persons.
- UNRWA health teams, including psychiatrists, psychosocial counsellors and supervisors, continued to provide MHPSS services in Gaza City, the Middle, and Khan Younis areas, assisting special cases referred from UNRWA health centres and collective emergency shelters. From 5 to 18 October, UNRWA teams conducted 6,317 visits in health centres and at health points providing individual consultations, awareness sessions, and support for protection cases.

Learning

- UNRWA provides learning services in the Gaza Strip in Temporary Learning Spaces (TLS) and through its distance learning initiative, with the support of over 7,000 teachers and education personnel.
- During the reporting period, 105,955 children (51,858 boys and 54,097 girls) took part in learning activities conducted across 84 UNRWA TLS.
- Complementing in-person learning, UNRWA also continues to leverage digital tools to support basic literacy and numeracy activities for approximately 280,000 children, using self-learning material developed by UNRWA and hosted on its digital learning platform.

Food security

- From 7 October 2023 until the start of the previous ceasefire on 19 January 2025, UNRWA reached over 388,000 families, or nearly 1.9 million people, with two rounds of flour deliveries; at

[5] The number of operational health facilities changes constantly based on demand, access and security. In particular, the number of medical points and teams in Gaza City continued to change due to heightened security risks and recurrent forced displacement orders.

least 374,000 of those families received three rounds. During that ceasefire, which lasted until March 2025, UNRWA reached over two million people with critical food assistance.

- **UNRWA ran out of food at the end of April 2025. The Agency has been blocked by the Israeli authorities from directly bringing in any humanitarian assistance including food since 2 March 2025.**

Water, Sanitation and Hygiene (WASH)

- Since October 2023, UNRWA has carried out emergency WASH activities across the Gaza Strip, at UNRWA collective emergency shelters and informal displacement areas. Activities include operating and maintaining water wells and desalination systems and supplying water by truck. In addition, UNRWA continues to maintain hygiene in its shelters and sites by distributing cleaning supplies, running community-based solid waste management, water tank disinfection campaigns, and pest control.
- In 2025, UNRWA distributed 970 million litres of drinking and domestic use water and collected and disposed of 70,000 tonnes of solid waste. UNRWA estimates that around 1.7 million people have so far benefitted from the Agency's water provision and solid waste collection services in 2026.
- Between 1 and 15 October, UNRWA distributed around 77 million litres of domestic and drinking water in various areas and from different sources, reaching over 800,000 displaced people daily.
- Between 1 and 15 October, UNRWA teams collected around 4,300 tonnes of garbage from the Agency's emergency shelters and surrounding areas and conducted 2,000 cleaning campaigns, reaching over 1.4 million displaced persons. Other activities during the reporting period included cleaning and clearing 941 manholes, as well as 480 water desludging activities and dewatering and cleaning of stormwater drainages. In total, 2,154 hygiene promotion sessions were also conducted during the same period.

Quote from Jamaela, an 80-year-old patient at an UNRWA clinic in Gaza:

"I am grateful that UNRWA continues to be there for people like me."

ENDs-

UNRWA response in the Gaza Strip

Health

Nearly 20 million health visits since October 2023

Over 146,700 health consultations provided between 5 and 18 October

Seven UNRWA health centres, five temporary health centres and 24 medical points operational

WASH

Over 800,000 people reached every day, with 77 million litres of domestic and drinking water provided between 1 and 15 October

Around 4,300 tonnes of garbage collected and transferred to temporary dumping sites between 1 and 15 October

2,154 hygiene promotion sessions and 2,000 cleaning campaigns conducted, benefitting over 1.4 million displaced persons between 1 and 15 October

Psychosocial support and learning

Around 730,000 displaced people, including over 520,000 children, reached with psychosocial support sessions and activities

Food assistance

No UNRWA supplies entered the Gaza Strip since 2 March 2025

In-person learning

Between 5 and 18 October, around 106,000 children participated in basic literacy and numeracy learning

Protection

Protection services provided to 6,230 GBV survivors and 12,052 children (including 4,373 unaccompanied children)